

Foucault and cultural governance

1. Foucault's Theoretical Foundations

Develops an analytics of power that shifts attention away from force and repression, towards how power works productively through knowledge, norms, and everyday practices.

Epistemes: the underlying structures of thought that define how an age understands truth and knowledge.

Discourses: forms of knowledge produced within an episteme; they operate as “regimes of truth.”

Order of discourse: a historically specific combination of ideas, institutions, practices, and beliefs that shape what can be said, known, and done.

Power is inseparable from knowledge: knowledge produces power, and power produces knowledge.

2. Discipline, Surveillance & Docile Bodies

Modern power works through non-coercive discipline rather than overt violence to create “docile and useful bodies.” A new class of “technicians of behaviour” emerges: These professionals render populations knowable so behaviour can be shaped and corrected.

3. Governmentality

Governmentality refers to the rationalities and techniques through which populations are governed. Develops in the 18th–19th centuries alongside urbanisation and population growth

4. Cultural Governance

Cultural governance examines how culture becomes a tool of government. Culture is managed through policy, institutions, and expertise. The roots lie in Victorian “rational recreation” Culture functions as a “reformer's science”

5. Surveillance, Media & Power

Contemporary governance relies heavily on surveillance technologies,

6. Changing Modes of Governance: The “Foucault Effect”

Later theorists apply Foucault to media and culture. Bennett argues power has shifted from surveillance to exhibition. The “exhibitionary complex”: